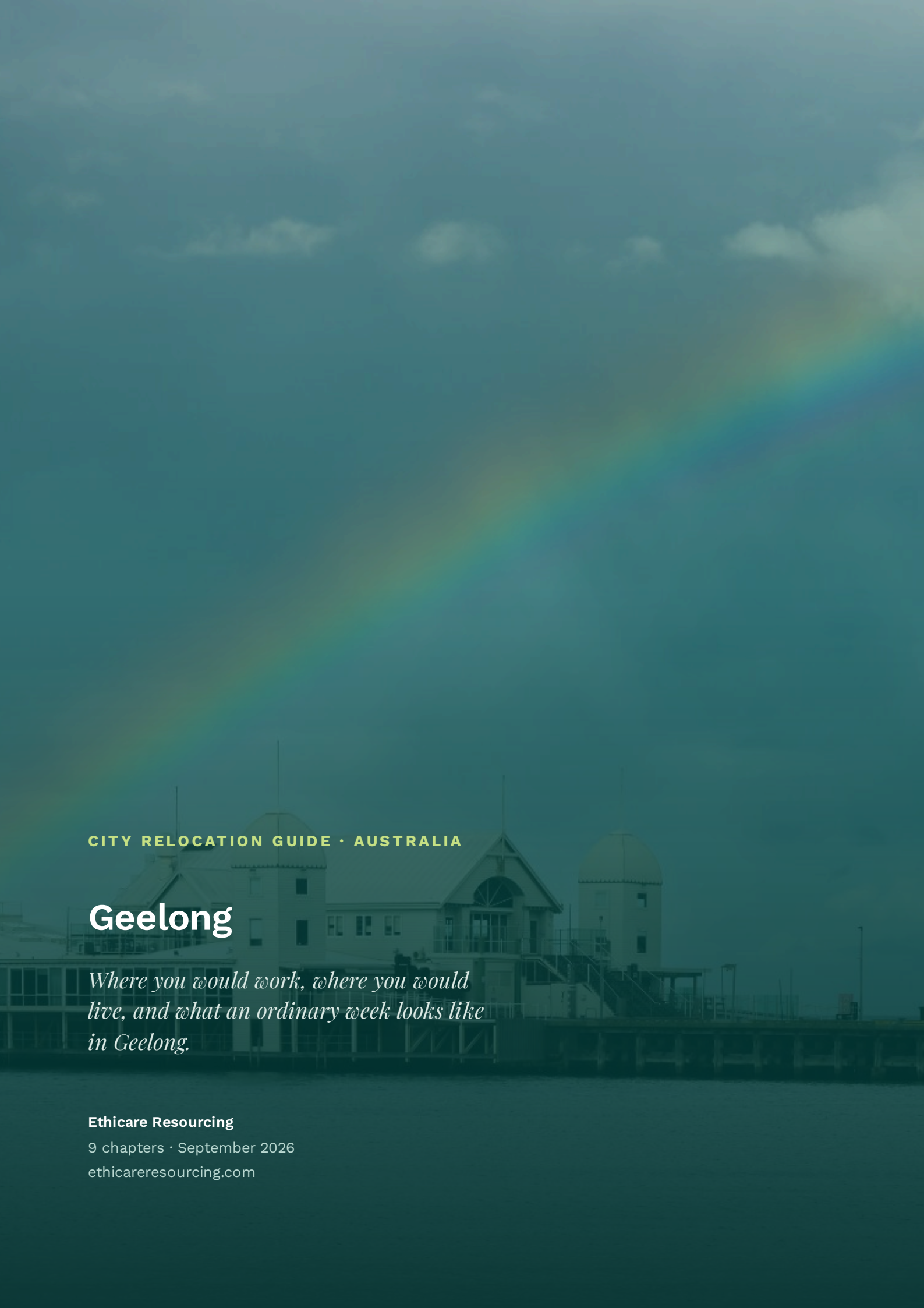




CITY RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Geelong

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Geelong.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Geelong

Geelong Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Geelong is the city that gives Melbourne a coastline of its own: Victoria's second city on Corio Bay, home to the only tertiary hospital in the state based outside Melbourne, with the Great Ocean Road starting at its edge. Here it is in nine numbers, then six things nobody tells you until you have moved.

A wool port that became a knowledge city

Around 270,000 people live across Greater Geelong, on Corio Bay about 75 kilometres south-west of Melbourne. It grew rich on wool in the nineteenth century — the reason for the grand civic architecture still standing in the centre — then on manufacturing through the twentieth: car assembly, an aluminium smelter and an oil refinery all operated here in turn. Within the last fifteen years all three closed, and the city rebuilt itself around health, education and the public sector instead. Two state government agencies moved their head offices to the waterfront, Deakin University expanded, and the local health service grew into Victoria's largest regional provider.

For clinicians the proposition is specific. The region's principal referral hospital is the only tertiary hospital in Victoria based outside metropolitan Melbourne, drawing a primary catchment of around 350,000 people and extending to roughly 500,000 for some specialist services. You get genuine tertiary breadth in a city of a quarter of a million, with Melbourne itself an hour up the road when you want it.

The honest costs: a specialist bench that, while real, is still smaller than a Melbourne teaching hospital's; a summer that brings the whole of Melbourne to the local beaches; and a wind off the bay that takes some getting used to. This guide prices all three plainly.

Who wrote this

We are a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide is not a pitch. Nothing in it asks you to register, and there is no visa advice.

Geelong suits people who want real tertiary work and a coastline, without needing everything a capital offers. Where we think it is the wrong fit, we say so.

The city, in nine numbers

~270,000

People across Greater Geelong, Victoria's largest regional city.

1 hr

To Melbourne by train or the Princes Freeway. A commute for some, a day trip for most.

Only

Tertiary hospital in Victoria based outside metropolitan Melbourne.

350,000

Primary catchment population for the region's principal referral hospital.

25 min

To Torquay and the start of the Great Ocean Road.

2

Deakin University campuses, including one built into the waterfront itself.

1850s

When the wool boom built the grand centre that still stands today.

Regional

Classification for skilled-migration purposes, despite the tertiary hospital.

20+

Cool-climate wineries across the Bellarine Peninsula and Moorabool Valley.



Corio Bay, the water the whole city is built around.

Six things you only learn once you are here

The wind has opinions

Geelong is genuinely breezier than Melbourne, exposed to both the bay and Bass Strait. A hot northerly followed by a cool change can move thirty degrees in an hour.

It is a Cats town

The Geelong Football Club runs deep here. Expect the city to notice, loudly, in September.

“Pako” is a place, not a joke

Pakington Street in Newtown is the café and shopping strip locals just call Pako. You will too, within a month.

The referral role is bigger than the city suggests

Case mix arrives from across the Barwon South West, not from Geelong’s population alone.

Old industry left a waterfront, not a scar

Where wool stores and a refinery once stood is now parkland, apartments and government offices. People still talk about “when Ford was here.”

Summer means visitors

The Bellarine and the Surf Coast are Melbourne’s nearest beach escape, so the roads and coastal towns get genuinely busy from Boxing Day to late January.

A note on Country

Geelong sits on the land of the Wadawurrung people, one of the five nations of the Kulin alliance.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the region, as it does across Victoria.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about Geelong specifically. Anything true of Australia generally — Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools — lives once in [Moving to Australia](#), so you read it once and not nine times.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Geelong](#) for the case honestly weighed, and [Healthcare in Geelong](#), because the tertiary role is the part most people underestimate.

Why Geelong

Geelong Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Most people who move here are trading Melbourne's scale for a hospital they can actually get to know, and a coastline at the end of the street. That trade is real, and so is what you give up. Both sides, plainly.

What Geelong is actually good at

Tertiary reach without the metro grind

The region's hospital is Victoria's only tertiary centre outside Melbourne, so the case complexity is genuine, but the commute is not a Melbourne commute.

Seniority arrives earlier

Smaller specialist teams than a Melbourne teaching hospital mean your name is on decisions sooner.

A commute measured in minutes

Most suburbs sit ten to twenty minutes from the hospital and the waterfront alike.

Housing that leaves room

Property costs materially less than Melbourne, without leaving the state's health and education systems behind.

Regional migration status

Geelong is classed as regional for skilled-migration purposes despite its size — a pathway Melbourne itself does not offer.

The coast is not a holiday, it's Tuesday

The Bellarine Peninsula and the start of the Great Ocean Road sit inside the everyday commute radius.

The Baywalk bollards — Geelong's waterfront, painted one figure at a time

What to weigh up

None of the following should stop you. All of them are worth knowing before you sign, because they are what people tell us they wish they had asked about.

Clinical

The bench is real but finite

Depth in your specialty exists, but it is a team, not a Melbourne teaching hospital's full department. Ask how many people sit alongside you specifically.

Clinical

Melbourne is the backstop for the rarest work

Occasionally a case goes to a Melbourne subspecialty service. Which ones depends on your specialty, and it is worth asking about directly at interview.

Practical

Summer brings the whole of Melbourne to your beach

The Bellarine and Surf Coast get genuinely busy from Boxing Day to late January. Locals plan around it rather than fight it.

Practical

The wind is a real feature, not a footnote

Exposed to Corio Bay and Bass Strait alike, Geelong is a noticeably breezier city than Melbourne. Outdoor plans need a backup.

Personal

It is a city of 270,000, not five million

A good range of cafés, restaurants and culture exists here. It is not Melbourne's range, and some people miss that; others find it a relief.

When another city is the better answer

If you need a large metropolitan subspecialty team around you, **Melbourne** is the honest recommendation – and close enough that Geelong can be a later move rather than a rejected one. If the draw is coastal lifestyle with regional breadth at a different latitude, **Newcastle** or **the Gold Coast** offer a similar shape. And if it is the Bellarine itself rather than Geelong specifically that appeals, the peninsula towns are worth a conversation, though the clinical roles are concentrated in Geelong, not out on the coast.

“

Geelong asks you to trade Melbourne's scale for a hospital you can actually get to know.

What clinicians tell us, in one sentence

A typical week

A ten to twenty-minute drive to work. A walk along the waterfront or Eastern Beach before or after a shift. Saturday morning on Pakington Street or at the Waterfront Farmers Market. An afternoon at Ocean Grove or Barwon Heads, or the Bellarine wineries, depending on the wind. The Great Ocean Road when you want a full day out. Melbourne when you want a gig, an airport or the MCG.

The short version

Geelong gives you Victoria's only tertiary case mix outside Melbourne, a commute in minutes and the Great Ocean Road at your back door, for materially less than Melbourne costs. What it asks in return is a smaller specialist bench and a city many times smaller than the capital. If that trade appeals, few places in Australia offer it this close to a state capital.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you want a capital's depth and sub-specialty range, **Melbourne** is an hour by train and the obvious comparison.

If regional Victoria is the real draw, the **Victoria brief** sets out the wider state and where the opportunities sit.

If you would take the same deal in New South Wales, **Newcastle** is its closest equivalent – a coastal second city two hours from Sydney.

In our experience

Geelong is the rare regional city where you can genuinely manage without a second car and still reach a capital for dinner. Clinicians who settle here tend to be the ones who wanted the coast and the Otways without giving up a city's services.

Geelong at a glance

Geelong Guide · Chapter 3 of 9



Geelong is easier to understand once you see it as a bay city that turned to face the water again. Almost everything about it – the waterfront, the wind, the way the suburbs spread – follows from Corio Bay.

The shape of the place

The city centre sits at the northern edge of Corio Bay, with the Barwon River running through the southern suburbs before reaching the sea at Barwon Heads. The Bellarine Peninsula extends south-east from the city, and the You Yangs – a granite range visible from most of Geelong – rise to the north-west.

What that means in practice: the inner suburbs and the waterfront are compact and walkable, the growth corridor runs south toward Armstrong Creek, and the Bellarine towns give you the coast with a genuine commute rather than a walk.

75 km

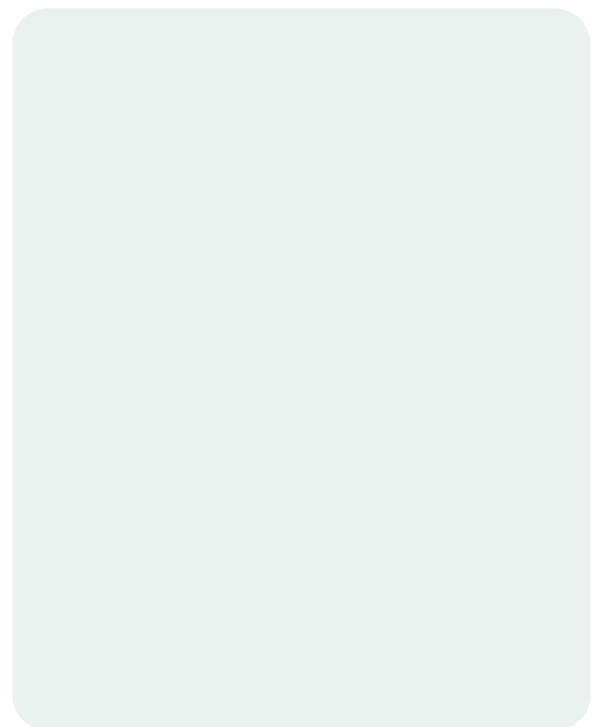
South-west of Melbourne

~270,000

Greater Geelong

Only

Tertiary hospital outside Melbourne



Where Geelong sits, with the straight-line distance to Melbourne and Torquay

The seasons, honestly

Geelong's climate is temperate and coastal, with more wind than Melbourne and slightly less rain than the hills further south. The difference between a still day and a blustery one can be the difference between a beach day and an indoor one.

Summer — Dec to Feb

Warm to hot, with hot inland northerlies sometimes followed by a sharp cool change off the bay within hours.

Autumn — Mar to May

Mild and settled — arguably the best swimming and the best light on the waterfront.

Winter — Jun to Aug

Cool and wet, with Bass Strait weather making itself felt. The wind is at its most noticeable.

Spring — Sep to Nov

Changeable and windy, with wildflowers on the You Yangs and the first warm days on the coast.

How the city got here

Long before

Wadawurrung Country

Corio Bay and the surrounding plains have been lived on and managed by the Wadawurrung people, part of the Kulin nation, for tens of thousands of years.

1830s

A port on the bay

European settlement followed the sheltered anchorage, exporting wool from the Western District's sheep runs.

19th century

The wool boom

Geelong grew wealthy enough to build the grand civic architecture that still defines the city centre.

20th century

A manufacturing city

Car assembly, an aluminium smelter and an oil refinery all operated here in turn, making Geelong one of Victoria's great industrial centres.

Today

A city that turned back to the water

All three heavy industries have closed within the last fifteen years. The waterfront has been rebuilt around people, two state agencies relocated their head offices here, and the local health and university sectors have grown to fill the gap.

What is here that you would not expect

Victoria's only tertiary hospital outside Melbourne

Two Deakin University campuses, one on the waterfront

The National Wool Museum, in a former woolstore

A working seaport still handling grain and fuel

One of the AFL's most fiercely supported clubs

A heritage carousel and painted bollards along the promenade

Cool-climate wine country twenty minutes from the CBD

The start of the Great Ocean Road at the edge of the municipality

Orientation, in one line

A bay city that built its wealth on wool, spent a century on heavy industry, and has spent the last fifteen years turning back to the water. Work out whether you want the inner city, the growth corridor or the Bellarine, and the rest of the map follows.

Healthcare in Geelong

Geelong Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Geelong punches above its population clinically, for one structural reason: its hospital is the only tertiary centre in Victoria based outside Melbourne. Understanding that designation is the difference between reading this as a regional posting and reading it accurately.

The system

A genuine tertiary centre

The region's principal referral hospital is the only tertiary hospital in Victoria based outside metropolitan Melbourne, and the largest hospital in regional Victoria.

A large catchment

Its primary catchment covers around 350,000 people, extending to roughly 500,000 for some specialist services drawn from further along the south-west coast.

District services behind it

Smaller hospitals and community health services across the Surf Coast, the Otways, Colac and the Bellarine refer inward for specialist and complex care.

A genuine private sector

Private hospitals and specialist imaging providers operate alongside the public system, giving real choice for clinicians and patients alike.

Melbourne is close, not essential

An hour up the freeway if a case needs a Melbourne subspecialty opinion, but the great majority of work is managed locally.

A note on names

We don't name hospitals, trusts or private providers as places of work anywhere on this site — a named employer implies a relationship, and the post and the package get confirmed with you directly.

Everything above is described structurally for that reason. If you want to know exactly where a role sits, ask us and we will tell you plainly.

What the tertiary role does to your work

A tertiary centre with a large regional catchment behind it pulls in two directions at once, and both are true of the same job.

What the region gives you

A case mix closer to a metropolitan teaching hospital than a typical regional posting — genuine subspecialty exposure, teaching relationships with Deakin University's medical and health-science programmes, and a role in the state's health system that carries real weight.

What it asks of you

Comfort working with a smaller specialist bench than a Melbourne teaching hospital, even while the case complexity is comparable.

Imaging and radiation, specifically

This is where our Australian work is concentrated, so it is the part we can speak to in most detail. As the only tertiary imaging service in regional Victoria, Geelong's capability sits closer to a metropolitan department than a typical regional posting — a full range of modalities, and a teaching relationship with Deakin University's health science programmes. For a technologist or radiographer that has a specific consequence: genuine subspecialty exposure is available without a five-million-person city built up around it, and cross-training tends to be actively supported rather than merely permitted.

Profession guide

Radiographers in Australia

Ahpra registration, the pathway in order, and what the role is really like.

Profession guide

Nuclear medicine in Australia

The registration route for technologists, and what to expect from the work.

Profession guide

Sonographers in Australia

ASAR accreditation, the pathway, and indicative pay.

Profession guide

Radiation therapists in Australia

Recognition of your training, scope of practice, indicative pay.

How pay works here

Registration is national but pay is not. In the public system, salaries are set by the relevant Victorian health system industrial agreement, negotiated between the health service and the union covering your profession — so the same role can sit on a different scale in another state. In the private sector, pay is negotiated individually and is often higher, particularly where a service is hard to staff.

We do not publish figures we have not verified against the agreement that actually governs the role. For the indicative bands and how the frameworks work, see [Salary in Australia, explained honestly](#).

What to ask at interview

How does the tertiary designation affect my day-to-day caseload?

Which cases, if any, go to a Melbourne subspecialty service?

How many colleagues sit alongside me in my specialty specifically?

What is the on-call pattern, and how often is it genuinely called upon?

Which modalities or sub-specialties would I be expected to cover?

What CPD time and funding is provided, including travel to Melbourne?

Is there a teaching component through Deakin, and is it supported?

The short version

Geelong is Victoria's only tertiary hospital outside Melbourne, which is why the clinical case mix is wider than the population suggests. The trade is a smaller specialist bench than a Melbourne teaching hospital — and for imaging specifically, a full-modality service most regional cities cannot offer.

Where clinicians live

Geelong Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



Geelong is compact enough that most commutes stay under twenty minutes, which frees you to choose on lifestyle rather than logistics. The real decision is inner city, growth corridor, or the Bellarine.

Make one decision first

Before you look at a single listing: fix your work site. The hospital and university precinct sits close to the CBD, while some services and clinics operate further out — and while nothing here is a long drive by Melbourne standards, the difference between a ten-minute and a thirty-minute commute is worth knowing before you sign a lease.

Then choose your shape of life. Inner suburbs mean cafés and walkability. The southern growth corridor means new housing and more space. The Bellarine means beach life with a genuine commute attached.

The areas, honestly

Newtown & Geelong West

Leafy and established, with Pakington Street's cafés and shops on the doorstep. Suits professionals without children or those who want to walk to dinner. Least space per dollar.

Herne Hill & Hamlyn Heights

Similar character a little further from the centre, with somewhat better value for a family-sized block.

Highton & Wandana Heights

Established and family-friendly, close to well-regarded schools and a short drive from the hospital precinct.

Belmont & Grovedale

Established southern suburbs near the Barwon River and the Waurin Ponds precinct, popular with families.

Armstrong Creek

The city's major growth corridor to the south — the newest and most affordable family housing, with a longer commute in.

The Bellarine towns

Ocean Grove, Barwon Heads, Drysdale and Portarlington offer genuine beach life with a twenty-five to forty-minute commute, and are increasingly sought after for exactly that reason.

Corio & Norlane

The city's more affordable northern suburbs, close to the ring road and undergoing gradual renewal.

Renting first is the sensible order

Almost everyone we place rents for six to twelve months before buying, and Geelong's market moves with the seasons as much as anything else – competition for Bellarine rentals rises sharply over summer. Arriving with something secured for your first month takes the pressure off the decision that matters more.

How leases, bonds, applications and tenancy rights work is the same across Australia and is covered once in [Moving to Australia](#). Nothing about renting in Geelong is legally different; it is the timing and the local competition that vary.

Practical, in order

Fix your work site before you choose a suburb.

Decide between inner city, growth corridor, or the Bellarine.

Rent for the first six to twelve months, and secure something before you fly.

Walk the street at the time of day you would actually be coming home.

If you are drawn to the Bellarine, drive the commute at peak on a summer weekend before committing – the traffic is real in January.

The short version

Nothing in Geelong is a difficult commute by Melbourne standards, so choose on the life rather than the drive. Inner city for walkability, the growth corridor for space, the Bellarine for the beach – and rent first, because the Bellarine market moves with the summer season.

Getting around

Geelong Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



The honest summary: a car makes life easier, but Geelong is also the most train-connected regional city in Victoria, and some households manage well without a second one.

Inside the city

Most trips across Geelong take ten to twenty minutes. A local bus network covers the suburbs, and the train line itself has local stops that double as inner-city transport. Parking is easier than Melbourne, though not as effortless as a small country town.

Cycling works well along the waterfront and the Barwon River trails, and Geelong's flat inner geography makes it a genuinely rideable city outside the windiest days.

~15 min

Most trips across the city

1 hr

To Melbourne by train or freeway

~20 min

To Avalon Airport

Getting to Melbourne

By road

About an hour up the Princes Freeway, dual carriageway the whole way. A normal commute for some, and the reason a Melbourne evening is an easy thing to do.

By train

A frequent direct service runs to Melbourne's Southern Cross Station in roughly sixty to seventy-five minutes — genuinely commutable, and some Geelong residents do it daily.

By air

Avalon Airport sits between Geelong and Melbourne with limited domestic and seasonal international services. For most international travel you will use Melbourne's main airport, about fifty minutes away.

By coach

Regional coach services connect Geelong to the Surf Coast, the Otways and towns further west, useful if you are without a car.

The car question, answered plainly

Useful, not always essential. If you live centrally and work at the hospital, the train line and local buses can genuinely cover daily life. A car earns its keep on weekends – the Bellarine, the Great Ocean Road and the wine regions are not well served by public transport, and that is where Geelong's real lifestyle argument lives.

Licence conversion, importing a vehicle, insurance and registration all work the same way across Australia and are covered once in [Living in Australia](#). Nothing about it is specific to Geelong.

First-month practicalities

If you plan to live centrally and use the train, confirm your actual commute time at your real start time, not the timetable's best case.

Check whether your accommodation has off-street parking – it varies more in the inner suburbs than further out.

If you are commuting from the Bellarine, drive the route once at your real start time before you commit to a lease.

Register for the Melbourne rail service early if you expect regular trips – peak services fill.

The short version

Geelong is the rare regional city where you can genuinely manage without a second car. Fifteen minutes to anything local, an hour to Melbourne by train – and the car earns its keep on Bellarine and Great Ocean Road weekends, not the daily commute.

Cost of living

Geelong Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Housing is most of the story. Almost everything else in Geelong costs close to Melbourne prices, and a couple of things cost more — which is a more useful way to think about it than a single index number.

Why there are no dollar figures on this page

We publish rents and prices only where we have verified them against current data, and a figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later. Rather than print numbers we cannot stand behind, this chapter tells you the shape of the difference and where to check the current position yourself. For the national picture — tax, superannuation, Medicare, banking and what a first year actually costs — see [Money, tax & banking in Australia](#).

What costs materially less

Geelong Housing — the largest single difference

Melbourne Noticeably higher to rent and to buy

Sydney A different order of magnitude

Relative widths are illustrative of direction, not measured values. Check current listings and the ABS or state data before you budget.

Housing, rented or bought

The reason many people move here and stay. What a clinical salary carries in Geelong is not comparable to what it carries in Melbourne, and the difference compounds over a career.

Parking and commuting

Generally easier and often free outside the CBD core, a real change from Melbourne's inner suburbs.

Space for the money

A family home with a garden is realistic on a single clinical income in a way it increasingly is not in Melbourne.

What costs about the same

Groceries, fuel, insurance, utilities, phone and internet all sit close to Melbourne levels. Australia is a national market for most of this, and Geelong is a large enough city to have real competition. Do not expect a regional discount on the weekly shop; do not expect a penalty either.

What costs more

Coastal accommodation in summer

The Bellarine and Surf Coast see Melbourne-level holiday pricing from Boxing Day to late January, which is worth knowing if you are house-hunting in that window.

Anything with a small local market

Specialist trades, certain hobbies and niche services. Not dramatically, but the choice is narrower than Melbourne, and that shows in price.

The one-off costs of the first year

These are the ones people underestimate, and they are the same wherever in Australia you land: visa and registration fees, flights, shipping or replacing furniture, a car, a rental bond, and the gap between arriving and your first pay. **Preparing to move** covers the national picture, and our **relocation cost calculator** will give you a personal estimate.

Where to check the current position

Current rental listings for the specific suburbs in **Where clinicians live** – the fastest reality check there is. State and ABS housing data for medians, rather than any figure on a recruiter's website.

Ask us what a role actually pays before you model anything. We will tell you the framework and the range.

The short version

Treat Geelong as Melbourne prices with a materially cheaper roof over your head, plus a premium on coastal accommodation in peak summer. The housing difference is the entire argument, and it is a large one.

Food, Pako & the everyday

Geelong Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

The test of a place is not its best restaurant. It is what an ordinary Wednesday feels like, and whether Saturday morning has a shape. Geelong does well on both, and one street does much of the work.

Pako is the centre of gravity

Pakington Street in Newtown — “Pako” to everyone who lives here — is the café and shopping strip that gives the inner suburbs their social life. It is not a tourist strip; it is where people actually spend a Saturday morning, and the standard of coffee and casual dining is genuinely high for a city this size.

Down at the water, the waterfront and Little Malop Street precincts carry most of the dinner-out trade, with views across Corio Bay thrown in. Between the two, a Saturday farmers’ market rotates through the region and is worth building a routine around.

Old shopfronts and independent shops in central Geelong

Eating out, honestly assessed

What is good

Café culture, casual dining on Pako and the waterfront, and a growing wine-region influence on the local food scene. For a city of 270,000 the standard is well above what the population would suggest.

What is thinner

The sheer range Melbourne carries. A specific niche cuisine may still mean an hour's drive, though the gap has narrowed noticeably in the last decade.

Where the wine comes from

The Bellarine Peninsula and the Moorabool Valley, both twenty to thirty minutes out – cool-climate pinot noir and chardonnay country, local by any reasonable definition.

Where to find groceries from home

The main supermarkets carry more than they used to, and Geelong's size supports a genuine range of specialist grocers. For anything unusual, Melbourne is an hour away.

A week, once the novelty has worn off

Weekdays

A short commute and light left in the evening

The thing people mention most is arriving home early enough for a walk along the waterfront before dinner.

Saturday morning

Pako, or the market

Coffee and errands on Pakington Street, or the rotating farmers' market, depending on the week.

Saturday afternoon

The water, or the wine

Eastern Beach or the Bellarine coast if the wind allows it, a Moorabool Valley cellar door if it does not.

Sunday

The Great Ocean Road, or nothing at all

Torquay and beyond for a proper day out, or the Barwon River trails if you would rather stay close to home.

Finding your people

Geelong is large enough to have genuine variety and small enough that joining something – a football club, a surf lifesaving club, a Deakin-adjacent community group – is a fast route in. Clinicians consistently tell us the professional community here feels close for a tertiary centre, partly because the specialist bench is smaller than Melbourne's.

On the wider question of community, faith and belonging – and being honest that a regional city carries smaller communities than a capital does – see [Community & belonging in Australia](#).

The short version

A good café strip, a wine region on the doorstep, and eating out that punches above the population. The real change is the shape of the week — a short commute buys back the evening, and Pako gives Saturday morning somewhere to be.

The Great Ocean Road, the Bellarine & the weekend



Geelong Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

This is the argument for Geelong that needs the least explaining. You are living at the start of one of the world's great coastal drives, with a capital city on the other side of you.

Twenty-five minutes: Torquay & Bells Beach

The official start of the Great Ocean Road, and the spiritual home of Australian surfing. Bells Beach hosts one of the sport's oldest professional contests, but the coastline either side is just as good for a beginner or a family. Close enough that it is a weeknight option, not just a weekend one.

Summer evenings on the waterfront

Thirty to forty minutes: the Bellarine

Ocean Grove & Barwon Heads

Family beach towns at the mouth of the Barwon River, popular enough that a summer weekend needs planning ahead.

Queenscliff

A heritage seaside town with a working ferry across Port Phillip Bay to the Mornington Peninsula – a genuine day trip in its own right.

The Bellarine wineries

Cool-climate cellar doors scattered across the peninsula, most within forty minutes of the city.

Portarlington & the mussel coast

A working fishing town on the calmer bay side, known locally for its mussels and a slower pace than the ocean beaches.

Two to three hours: the Great Ocean Road proper

Lorne, Apollo Bay, the Otway rainforest and the Twelve Apostles are all reachable as a long day out, or better as an overnight. It is one of the world's great coastal drives, and Geelong is where it starts rather than somewhere you fly into to see it.

Thirty to forty minutes inland: the Moorabool Valley & the You Yangs

Cool-climate wine country to the west, and an easy granite-range walk at the You Yangs with views back over Corio Bay and, on a clear day, the Melbourne skyline. The reminder that Geelong's hinterland is not only coastline.

In the city itself

A walk or swim at Eastern Beach

The waterfront carousel and painted bollards

The National Wool Museum

Kardinia Park on an AFL match day

The Barwon River trails for cycling or running

The Geelong Gallery

Deakin University's waterfront campus and public spaces

A Saturday on Pakington Street

“

People fly into Melbourne to drive the road that starts at the end of your street.

The Great Ocean Road, in one sentence

The short version

Bells Beach in twenty-five minutes, the Bellarine in forty, the Twelve Apostles in a long day, and Melbourne itself in an hour the other direction. Geelong is not near the coast – it is where the coast starts, and that is what keeps people here after the job stops being new.

Where to next

The national guide

Moving to Australia

Visas, registration, Medicare, tax, schools and renting – explained once, for the whole country.

An hour away

Melbourne

The capital, the tertiary subspecialty centres, and the honest comparison if you are weighing the two.

Live roles

Current opportunities

What is open now across Australia, including regional Victoria.

No pressure

Talk it through

Whether you are curious or close to deciding, a conversation costs nothing.